



In overly wet soils, water fills airy spaces.

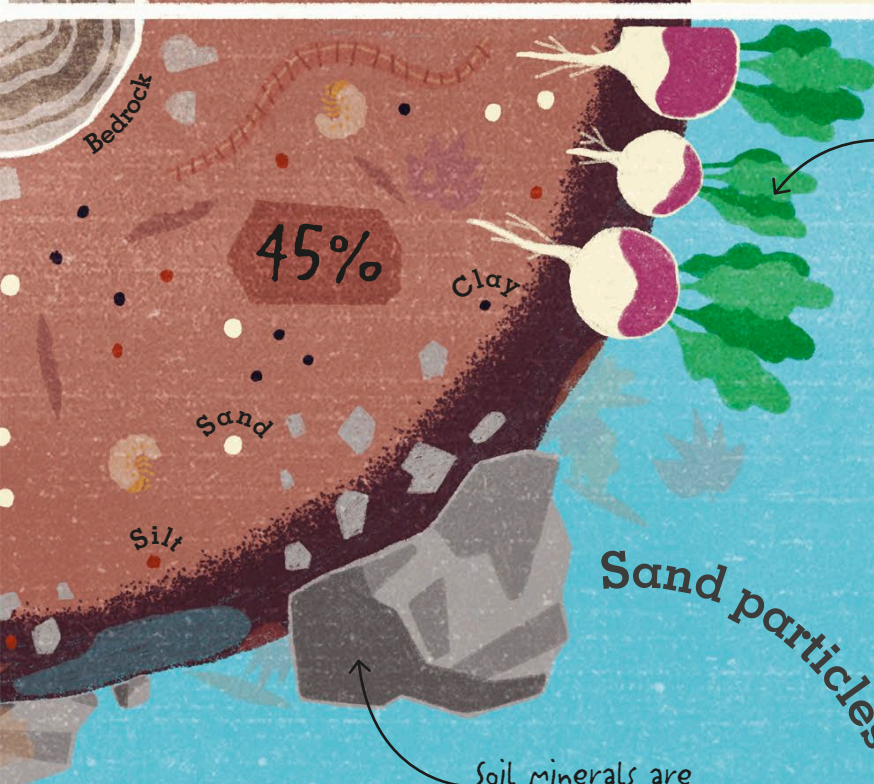
Air

Organisms live and grow best in soils with almost equal amounts of air and water, which they need to survive. Air moves through the soil in cracks, burrows, and pores.

Centipedes take in air through holes along their bodies.

20-30%

Beetles begin their lives underground, where they need air to breathe.



Turnips grow well in loose, sandy soils.

Minerals

A mineral is a solid that is found naturally and made of crystals. In soil, the gritty mineral ingredient includes particles called sand, silt, and clay. Some plants grow well in sandy soils, but others prefer soils with lots of clay particles.

Sand particles can be 1,000 times bigger than clay.

Soil minerals are worn away from rocks on the surface and from bedrock.